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Strategic Brief

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US Launches Second Night of Strikes on Iran as Ceasefire Unravels, NATO Pledges Billions, Le Pen Defies Court

The Bottom Line

The US-Iran ceasefire is effectively over after two consecutive nights of American strikes on Iranian territory and Iranian retaliatory attacks on Gulf bases — and the chances of a long-term agreement now look slimmer than they have since the war began. At NATO, allies mobilised significant resources (£37bn for a new missile, €70bn for Ukraine) but the alliance's internal fractures were on full display, with Trump attacking Spain, threatening trade cuts, and reviving his Greenland ambition. France's Le Pen launched a presidential campaign despite a corruption conviction that should have ended her career — a reminder that the European political landscape remains volatile. In Syria, the US removed a 47-year terrorism designation, betting on a former rebel leader's ability to rebuild a shattered country. And in Sudan and China, humanitarian crises continued to escalate with no end in sight.